LONDON LEKGOTLA

New Joiners Handbook 2026

Pan-African in spirit · Southern African in strategy

Moving to the UK: A Practical Guide for Southern African Professionals

WELCOME TO LONDON LEKGOTLA

London Lekgotla was founded to give Southern Africans in the UK a space to **connect, organise, and belong**. Given our region's unique history, many of us arrive without extended family, older generations, or established community infrastructure, which can leave us professionally visible but socially isolated.

We draw deep inspiration from Black professionals across the UK: from West African, Caribbean, and pan-African communities who have built powerful networks of visibility, advocacy, and support. London Lekgotla exists alongside these spaces, not instead of them.

Our focus on Southern Africa reflects a need for cultural fluency, strategic focus, and a desire to address region-specific barriers: from underrepresentation in leadership to building philanthropic bridges back home.

Pan-African in spirit. Southern African in strategy. Committed to rising together.

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Living document. Suggestions welcome via our feedback form.

HOW WE TREAT EACH OTHER

London Lekgotla is a space built on trust, mutual respect, and a shared commitment to one another's wellbeing. These rules reflect the values of the community, and every member is expected to uphold them.

Zero Tolerance for Hate Speech and Discrimination

South Africa's history demands that we hold ourselves to a higher standard. We carry that history with us, and with it a responsibility to build something different.

Hate speech, discrimination, or derogatory language directed at any person on the basis of race, ethnicity, national origin, gender, sexuality, religion, disability, or any other protected characteristic will result in immediate removal from the community. This applies equally to comments about African nationals from other countries. We are Pan-African in spirit: we do not tolerate the othering of our continental neighbours.

Respect for Member Privacy

- What is shared in the community stays in the community.
- Do not screenshot or republish private group conversations.
- Do not use information shared in the community for unsolicited commercial approaches or recruitment without consent.

Professional Conduct

- The community channels are not platforms for unsolicited sales pitches or spam.
- Disagreements happen. Engage respectfully and in good faith. Personal attacks are not welcome.

Membership is a privilege, and with it comes the responsibility to show up as the version of yourself you want to model for others.

02 STAY CONNECTED

COMMUNITY CHANNELS

WhatsApp Group

Our WhatsApp group is the heartbeat of the community: event announcements, quick questions, job leads, and moral support. Ask a current member for the invite link or reach out via LinkedIn.

LinkedIn

Follow and connect with us: linkedin.com/company/london-lekgotla.

Website

londonlekgotla.com — our community hub with the New Joiners handbook, events, and join form.

VISA AND IMMIGRATION

Check eligibility at gov.uk/check-uk-visa. The information below reflects rules in force from July 2025. Always verify before applying.

Important: The rules are changing significantly

The Labour government published a major immigration White Paper in May 2025 and began implementing changes from July 2025. Salary thresholds have risen, skill requirements have been tightened, and the settlement pathway is being restructured.

Skilled Worker Visa

Requires a job offer from a licensed UK sponsor, a minimum salary of **£41,700 per year** (or the occupation going rate, whichever is higher), and English at **B2 level** from January 2026. From July 2025, the minimum skill level is **RQF Level 6** (degree level).

Other Routes

- **Global Talent Visa:** For leaders or potential leaders in academia, arts, architecture, fashion design, digital technology, and film or television.
- **Ancestry Visa:** If you have a UK-born grandparent, five years of work rights with an ILR pathway.
- **Spouse or Partner Visa:** Sponsoring partner must earn at least £29,000, rising to £38,700 by early 2026.
- **Global Business Mobility:** General salary threshold is £52,500 from July 2025.

TB TEST: REQUIRED BEFORE YOU ARRIVE

If your visa is valid for more than six months, you must provide a TB certificate from a Home Office-approved clinic before your visa is granted. In South Africa, testing is done through the IOM. You cannot use a private radiologist.

The BCG complication for South Africans

South Africans receive the BCG vaccine at birth, which can cause a false positive on the Mantoux skin test (TST). The IGRA blood test (Quantiferon Gold) is not affected by prior BCG vaccination and is the preferred test. Always inform your clinic you received the BCG at birth.

Latent TB does not prevent a visa being granted.

Healthcare Immigration Surcharge (IHS)

Current rate: **£1,035 per year** per person. Budget for this as part of your total visa cost.

INDEFINITE LEAVE TO REMAIN

Major change in progress: qualifying period likely to increase to 10 years

Current rules require five years for most routes. The 2025 White Paper proposes ten years for most work-based routes, with a shorter period possible for those making strong economic or social contributions. Not yet law as of June 2025, but expected.

What this means for you: if you are on a Skilled Worker visa and currently counting down to your five-year ILR date, the change is not expected to apply retrospectively to time already spent in the UK under the current rules. However, anyone who entered the route after the new rules take effect may face a longer qualifying period. Start tracking your absences from day one and seek immigration advice if you are approaching your ILR date when the new rules come into force.

Accelerated settlement (potentially around six years) may be available for those who demonstrate strong economic contribution, community integration, and compliance with immigration rules. The detailed criteria are still being finalised by the Home Office.

The 180-Day Absence Rule

Track this from Day 1. No more than 180 days absent in any rolling 12-month period. Exceeding this can reset your qualifying period.

- Free absence calculator: ilrtracker.com/tools/ilr-absence-calculator
- Subject Access Request for official travel history: visas-immigration.service.gov.uk/product/saru

BRITISH CITIZENSHIP

After holding ILR for 12 months and living in the UK for five years total.

- No more than **450 days** absent during the five-year qualifying period.
- No more than **90 days** absent in the 12 months immediately before your application.

Life in the UK Test

24 questions, 45 minutes, 75% pass mark. Cost: **£50** per attempt. Book at gov.uk/life-in-the-uk-test.

English Language Evidence for South Africans

You need from Ecctis an **AQUALS** (degree equivalence) and an **ELPS** (taught in English), via the **QLS** service at qls.ecctis.com. Cost: £210 plus VAT, 20 working days.

SA dual citizenship update: May 2025

The Constitutional Court ruled Section 6(1)(a) of the SA Citizenship Act unconstitutional. Anyone who lost citizenship between 1995 and May 2025 is deemed not to have lost it. The Certificate of Non-Acquisition and Retention Letter process are expected to fall away. Verify with the SA High Commission (15 Whitehall, London SW1A 2DD) before spending money on documents.

05 TAX, PAYSLIPS AND COUNCIL TAX

UK TAX

- Income tax and NI are deducted via PAYE automatically.
- Apply for your **NI number** as soon as you arrive. Needed for work, ISAs, and many services.
- UK tax year: **6 April to 5 April**. File a self-assessment return only if you have income outside PAYE.
- 2025/26 rates: Personal Allowance £12,570 (0%), Basic Rate 20% (up to £50,270), Higher Rate 40% (up to £125,140), Additional Rate 45% above.

UNDERSTANDING YOUR PAYSLIP

Your first UK payslip can look confusing. Here is what the main lines mean:

Line	What it means
Gross Pay	Your full salary before any deductions.
Income Tax	Deducted at your marginal rate via PAYE. Your tax code (e.g. 1257L) determines how much. Check at gov.uk/tax-codes.
National Insurance	Employee NI is 8% on earnings between £12,570 and £50,270, and 2% above that. Separate from income tax.
Student Loan	Deducted automatically if you have a UK or eligible overseas student loan.
Pension	If enrolled in a workplace pension (auto-enrolment after 3 months), your employee contribution appears here.
Net Pay	What actually arrives in your bank account.

Check your tax code. 1257L is the standard for 2025/26. If yours looks different, contact HMRC.

COUNCIL TAX

Council Tax is a local authority tax on residential properties, charged to the occupant. It funds refuse collection, parks, and local government.

- Properties are assigned a band (A to H). Check yours at gov.uk/council-tax-bands.
- Full-time students are exempt. Claim through your university and notify your council.
- Single occupants receive a 25% discount. Apply through your local council website.

- Most councils allow 10 monthly instalments. Set up a direct debit as soon as you move in.

SOUTH AFRICAN TAX

The SA-UK Double Taxation Agreement

Unless you have formally broken your SA tax residency, SARS may still require you to declare worldwide income. The DTA prevents double taxation but you may still need to file a SARS return annually.

Formal cessation of SA tax residency triggers a deemed disposal exit tax. Seek advice from Sable International or FinGlobal before proceeding.

File at sars.gov.za. Filing season opens in July each year.

06 VOTING RIGHTS AND UK POLITICAL PARTIES

YES: SOUTH AFRICANS CAN VOTE IN THE UK

As a qualifying Commonwealth citizen with valid leave to remain, you can register to vote in UK Parliamentary elections, local government elections, Mayoral elections, and Police and Crime Commissioner elections. This is a right many of us do not know we have.

- Register at gov.uk/register-to-vote. Takes five minutes. Requires your NI number.

UK POLITICAL PARTIES AT A GLANCE

Understanding the political landscape helps you engage meaningfully in civic life. Here is a brief overview of the main parties:

Labour Party (Centre-Left)

Focus on the NHS, public services, workers' rights, and economic growth. Generally supports a larger role for government in delivering services. Currently in government (2024 onwards).

- labour.org.uk

Conservative Party (Centre-Right)

Focus on business, economic growth, lower taxes, law and order, and controlled immigration. Generally supports a smaller role for government and greater individual responsibility.

- conservatives.com

Liberal Democrats (Centrist)

Focus on civil liberties, education, mental health, and electoral reform. Generally pro-European and supportive of international cooperation.

- libdems.org.uk

Green Party (Progressive/Environmental)

Focus on climate change, environmental protection, and social justice. Supports significant investment in green infrastructure and public services.

- greenparty.org.uk

Reform UK (Right-Wing)

Focus on reducing immigration, lowering taxes, and reforming government institutions. Often positions itself as an alternative to the traditional major parties.

- reformparty.uk

Scottish National Party (SNP)

Focus on Scottish interests and Scottish independence. Primarily relevant for those living in Scotland.

- snp.org

Before You Vote

- Read party manifestos before elections.
- Follow multiple news sources to understand different perspectives.
- Register to vote as soon as you become eligible.
- Local elections often have a direct impact on housing, transport, schools, and council tax.

> ***London Lekgotla's Position***
>
> London Lekgotla is **politically non-partisan**. We encourage members to engage in civic life, understand the issues, and participate in the democratic process regardless of political affiliation. Voting is one of the most meaningful ways to shape the country you are building your life in.

NEOBANKS: START ON DAY ONE

If you lack the documents required by traditional banks, a neobank lets you get a UK account and card from day one using just your passport.

- **Revolut:** Multi-currency wallets, ISA products. revolut.com
- **Monzo:** Strong budgeting tools. monzo.com
- **Starling Bank:** Excellent for freelancers. starlingbank.com

TRADITIONAL BANKS

Once you have three months of payslips and a proof of address, open a traditional account to build a more established credit profile.

Bank	Account opening link
HSBC	hsbc.co.uk/current-accounts
Barclays	barclays.co.uk/current-accounts
Lloyds	lloydsbank.com/current-accounts
NatWest	natwest.com/current-accounts
Santander	santander.co.uk/personal/current-accounts
Halifax	halifax.co.uk/currentaccounts

All banks require valid photo ID and proof of address. If you do not yet have a UK utility bill, a letter from your employer or university is usually accepted. Most offer online applications. Entry-level current accounts (rather than those with overdraft facilities) are the usual starting point with no UK credit history.

CREDIT SCORE

You arrive with no UK credit history. Building it takes time and intention.

- **Check for free:** experian.co.uk, equifax.co.uk, or clearscore.com.
- Register on the electoral roll as soon as eligible: fastest way to improve your score.
- Get a starter credit card (Capital One or Aqua) and pay it in full every month.
- Keep all direct debits on time. Even a missed phone bill stays on record for six years.

- Avoid multiple credit applications in a short period.

ISAs AND SAVING

Any growth inside an ISA is **completely free of UK tax**. Annual allowance: **£20,000 per tax year**.

- **Stocks and Shares ISA:** Invest in equities and ETFs. Revolut offers a flexible ISA with no platform fee.
- **Lifetime ISA (LISA):** Up to **£4,000/year** with a **25% government bonus**. For a first home (under £450,000) or retirement. Must be aged 18 to 39 to open. Top providers: Moneybox, Tembo, AJ Bell Dodl. Note: closes to new applications April 2028.

UTILITIES SETUP CHECKLIST

Contact utility providers immediately when you move in. Ask the landlord or previous tenant who the current suppliers are.

- **Electricity and gas:** Compare at uswitch.com. Major suppliers: British Gas, E.ON, EDF, Octopus Energy, Ovo Energy.
- **Broadband:** Compare at broadbandchecker.co.uk. Major providers: BT, Sky, Virgin Media, Hyperoptic, Vodafone.
- **Water:** Supplied by a regional monopoly. Not a matter of choice.
- **Council Tax:** Register with your local council within a few days of moving in.
- **TV Licence:** Required if you watch live TV on any device or use BBC iPlayer. Currently **£174.50 per year**. Apply at tvlicensing.co.uk.

SIM CARD AND MOBILE

- **giffgaff:** No contract, bundles from around £10/month. Order a free SIM online before you arrive.
- **Smarty:** No contract SIMs with competitive data rates.
- **EE, O2, Vodafone, Three:** Major networks with better coverage. Contracts may require a credit check.

GYMS

- **Virgin Active:** Your UK membership grants access to Virgin Active clubs in South Africa. virginactive.co.uk
- **Equinox:** Premium. Popular in the City and Kensington. Expect £150 to £250/month.
- **Third Space:** High-end with strong community. Canary Wharf, Soho, and other central locations.
- **Gymbox:** Fun, high-energy, London-focused. Good value relative to premium options.
- **PureGym and The Gym Group:** Affordable, no-contract options from around £20 to £30/month.
- **David Lloyd:** Family-friendly with pools and racquet sports.

FINDING A PROPERTY

- **Rightmove:** rightmove.co.uk
- **Zoopla:** zoopla.co.uk
- **SpareRoom:** spareroom.co.uk for flatshares.

Approximate Monthly Rents (2025/26)

Area	1-bed flat	Room in flatshare
Central London	£2,000 to £2,800	£900 to £1,400
Outer London	£1,500 to £2,000	£700 to £1,100
Other major cities	£800 to £1,300	£500 to £800

Living in Zone 2 or 3 rather than Zone 1 can save £500 to £800/month on rent with commute times of 20 to 40 minutes. Popular value areas: Stratford, Walthamstow, Brixton, Peckham, Elephant and Castle.

YOUR RIGHTS AS A TENANT: THE RENTERS' RIGHTS ACT 2025

Major provisions take effect from **1 May 2026**:

- **No more no-fault evictions:** Section 21 is abolished.
- **Rolling tenancies:** All private tenancies become periodic. You can end with two months' notice.
- **Rent increases:** Only once a year, at market rate.
- No bidding wars. Pet rights. Anti-discrimination provisions.

Always insist on deposit protection

Your landlord must protect your deposit in a government-approved scheme within 30 days: **DPS**, **MyDeposits**, or **TDS**. Ask for written confirmation. Failure entitles you to claim one to three times the deposit in compensation. Deposit capped at five weeks' rent.

BUYING PROPERTY

- Visa holders can buy property in the UK with no restrictions.
- **SA homeowner stamp duty note:** If you own property in SA, HMRC may add a 3% SDLT surcharge.
- Use a mortgage broker experienced with visa holders: Habito, L&C;, or Trussle.
- Best LISA providers: Moneybox and Tembo. Property cap: £450,000. A 12-month wait applies before use.

10 HOME SUPPORT: CLEANING AND CHILDCARE

DOMESTIC CLEANING

Hiring someone fortnightly or monthly is common among busy professionals. Budget approximately £50 to £80 per session for a one-bedroom flat.

- **Wecasa:** Vetted cleaners, app-based booking, from around £18/hour. wecasa.co.uk
- **Housekeep:** London-focused vetted cleaning service with regular and one-off options. housekeep.com
- **Taskrabbit:** Good for one-off jobs and same-day bookings. taskrabbit.co.uk
- **Handy:** App-based cleaning platform. Cleaners bring their own equipment. handy.com

Word of mouth via the community WhatsApp is often the best route for a trusted regular cleaner.

CHILDCARE AND NANNIES

Childcare in the UK is expensive and in high demand. Start looking well in advance. All professionally placed nannies will have an enhanced DBS check.

- **Childcare.co.uk:** UK's largest childcare marketplace. childcare.co.uk
- **The Nanny Connection:** Boutique London agency, strong reviews. nannyconnection.co.uk
- **Superstar Nannies:** Well-regarded for high-quality placements. superstarnannies.com

11 HEALTHCARE AND VACCINES

THE NHS

- **Register with a GP** as soon as you arrive: nhs.uk/service-search/find-a-gp.
- **NHS 111:** Urgent but non-emergency care.
- **999 or 112:** Emergencies.
- **101:** Non-urgent police matters.
- **Prescriptions:** £9.90 per item. GP and hospital services are free.

EMERGENCY SERVICES: ADDITIONAL OPTIONS

Beyond the NHS, several community-based emergency services operate in London:

- **Hatzalah:** A Jewish volunteer emergency medical service operating in North London and other communities. Staffed by trained paramedics and first responders. Open to all regardless of background in a genuine emergency. hatzalah.org.uk
- **LIVES (Christian-affiliated):** Community first responder network operating in parts of the UK. Volunteers respond alongside the ambulance service. Coverage varies by area. Note: all emergency volunteer services respond to those in need regardless of faith. lives.org.uk

In a life-threatening emergency, always call 999 first. These services operate alongside, not instead of, the NHS ambulance service.

VACCINES YOU MAY HAVE MISSED

Ask your GP to review your vaccination record when you register.

- **HPV:** NHS catch-up campaign for unvaccinated 18 to 25-year-olds (2025/26). Outside the free age, available privately for around £150 to £300.
- **MenACWY:** Meningitis protection. Those up to age 25 may be eligible for a free catch-up dose.
- **MMR:** Two doses protect against measles, mumps, and rubella. Free catch-up on the NHS.
- **Flu:** Free annually if pregnant, over 65, or with certain health conditions.

TB testing: the BCG complication

The BCG vaccine (given at birth in SA) can cause a false positive on the Mantoux skin test. The **IGRA (Quantiferon Gold) blood test** is not affected by prior BCG vaccination. Always inform your GP or clinic that you received the BCG at birth.

DENTAL CARE: THIS CATCHES MANY NEWCOMERS BY SURPRISE

- **Band 1 (£26.80):** Examination and preventive advice.
- **Band 2 (£73.50):** Fillings, root canal, or extractions.
- **Band 3 (£319.10):** Crowns, dentures, or bridges.
- NHS dentists are scarce. Register as soon as you arrive. You may need to join a waiting list.

MENTAL HEALTH RESOURCES

- **NHS Talking Therapies (IAPT):** Free CBT. Self-refer at nhs.uk self-referral search.
- **Samaritans:** 24/7 support. Call **116 123** (free). samaritans.org
- **Mind:** Mental health charity with local services. mind.org.uk
- **Shout:** Free crisis text service. Text SHOUT to 85258.
- Your employer's EAP (Employee Assistance Programme) usually offers free confidential counselling.

PRIVATE HEALTH INSURANCE

Key differences from South African medical aid

Pre-existing conditions are typically excluded permanently.

Chronic conditions (diabetes, asthma, hypertension) are managed by the NHS, not PMI.

Emergencies go to the NHS. PMI provides faster specialist access and elective procedures.

Changing jobs: employer PMI ends when you leave. Conditions treated during a gap can become pre-existing exclusions with the new insurer. Check policy terms before resigning.

12 FAMILY: PARENTAL LEAVE, CHILD BENEFIT AND CHILDCARE

MATERNITY AND PATERNITY LEAVE

Type	Duration	Rate (2025/26)
Statutory Maternity Pay (SMP)	Up to 39 weeks	First 6 weeks: 90% of earnings. Weeks 7 to 39: £187.18/week or 90%, whichever is lower.
Statutory Paternity Pay (SPP)	1 or 2 weeks	£187.18/week or 90% of earnings, whichever is lower.
Shared Parental Leave	Up to 50 weeks combined	Same rate as SPP for the shared portion.

Rates rise to £194.32/week from 6 April 2026. Paternity leave becomes a day-one right from April 2026.

CHILD BENEFIT

Not means-tested and must be claimed actively. Many families miss out by not applying.

- 2025/26 rates: **£26.05/week** for your first child; **£17.25/week** for each additional child.
- If either partner earns over £60,000, a tax charge claws back some or all. At £80,000 the full amount is repaid. Still worth claiming for the NI credits toward State Pension.
- Apply at gov.uk/child-benefit.

FREE CHILDCARE HOURS AND TAX-FREE CHILDCARE

- **30 hours free childcare (from September 2025):** For working parents with children aged 9 months to school age. Both parents must earn the equivalent of at least 16 hours/week at National Minimum Wage and neither can earn above £100,000. Apply at gov.uk/get-childcare.
- **15 hours free:** All 3 and 4-year-olds are entitled regardless of parental income.
- **Tax-Free Childcare:** For every £8 you pay in, the government adds £2, up to **£500 every three months** per child (£1,000 if the child is disabled).

13 PROFESSIONAL ACCREDITATION

QUALIFYING IN THE UK

Many professions require registration with a UK regulatory body before you can practise. Do not assume your SA qualifications transfer automatically. Start well in advance.

Profession	Body	Website
Doctors (all specialties)	General Medical Council (GMC)	gmc-uk.org
Nurses and midwives	Nursing and Midwifery Council (NMC)	nmc.org.uk
Solicitors and lawyers	Solicitors Regulation Authority (SRA)	sra.org.uk
Barristers	Bar Standards Board (BSB)	barstandardsboard.org.uk
Chartered accountants	ICAEW / ACCA / CIMA	icaew.com
Engineers (Chartered)	Engineering Council (ICE, IMechE, IET)	engc.org.uk
Architects	Architects Registration Board (ARB)	arb.org.uk
Financial advisers	Financial Conduct Authority (FCA)	fca.org.uk
Dentists	General Dental Council (GDC)	gdc-uk.org

GMC registration for doctors can take several months and requires language tests, document verification, and sometimes supervised practice. Keep a certified copy of every document you submit.

14 EDUCATION AND TRANSPORT

EDUCATION

- Compulsory for children aged 5 to 16. State schools are free.
- Contact your local council to find available school places.
- If studying, apply for university accommodation first.

GETTING AROUND LONDON

Contactless vs Oyster

Tap your contactless bank card directly on Tube gates and bus stops. No setup required. Oyster applies a weekly cap that contactless currently does not, so regular commuters save money with Oyster plus a Travelcard.

Navigation Apps

- **Citymapper:** Best for real-time disruptions and multi-mode routes. citymapper.com
- **TfL Go:** Official TfL app. Real-time Tube arrivals and lift status.
- **National Rail App:** For intercity travel.

CONVERTING YOUR SOUTH AFRICAN LICENCE TO A UK LICENCE

South Africa is on the DVLA's designated country list, meaning you can exchange your SA driving licence for a UK licence without taking a theory or practical test. This must be done within 12 months of becoming a UK resident.

What you need:

- **Your original SA driving licence** (the new credit-card style). Old book licences are no longer valid for exchange.
- **D1 application form:** Available from a post office offering DVLA services.
- **Confirmation letter from the RTMC** (Road Traffic Management Corporation). Request by emailing the RTMC with your ID and driving licence. Allow extra time.
- Proof of identity (passport) and proof of UK address.

Important notes

You must send your original SA licence to the DVLA. It will not be returned. Make a certified copy before you send it.

If your SA licence expires during processing, the DVLA may reject the exchange.

Processing typically takes 3 to 4 weeks.

Apply: gov.uk/exchange-foreign-driving-licence

16 CULTURE, COMMUNITY AND BLACK PROFESSIONAL NETWORKS

SOUTHERN AFRICAN SPOTS

- **Vivat Bacchus** (Farringdon and London Bridge): London's flagship SA restaurant and wine bar. Boerewors, ostrich, braai boards, London's largest SA wine list. vivatbacchus.co.uk
- **High Timber:** SA-inspired dining with Thames views. Near Mansion House station. hightimber.com
- **Tasha's Battersea:** SA all-day cafe near Battersea Power Station station.
- **Kudu Restaurant:** SA-inspired tasting menus in Peckham.
- **Safari Biltong:** Available at Tube station concessions including Charing Cross, Canary Wharf, and Victoria. safaribiltong.com
- **Max's Biltong and Snoggy's:** Ask in the community WhatsApp for current stockist locations.

The Newt in Somerset

Owned by SA's Koos Bekker and Karen Roos (also behind Babylonstoren). A Babylonstoren wine club membership (£100/quarter) includes access to The Newt's gardens, shops, and restaurants, plus 20% off Babylonstoren wines. Approximately two hours from London to Castle Cary by train.

thenewtinsomerset.com | babylonstoren.com

BLACK PROFESSIONAL NETWORKS IN THE UK

London Lekgotla is one part of a broader ecosystem. We encourage all members to engage widely.

- **BYP Network (Black Young Professionals):** Career advancement platform, job board, mentorship, and the annual BYP Leadership Conference. byp.network
- **Black Women in Asset Management (BWAM):** Free membership for women in investment management, private equity, and venture capital. Annual conference and job board. bwam.network
- **EnCircle:** A network dedicated to connecting and empowering Black professionals across industries in the UK, with events, mentorship, and community initiatives. encircle.community
- **Black Tech Fest:** Europe's largest celebration of Black culture and technology.
- **UK Black Business Show:** Annual event focused on Black entrepreneurship and professional development.
- **AFBE-UK:** Association for Black and Minority Ethnic Engineers. afbe.org.uk

17 USEFUL LINKS AND CLOSING NOTE

USEFUL LINKS AT A GLANCE

- **Check visa options:** gov.uk/check-uk-visa
- **Home Office SAR (travel history):** visas-immigration.service.gov.uk/product/saru
- **ILR absence calculator:** ilrtracker.com/tools/ilr-absence-calculator
- **Life in the UK test:** gov.uk/life-in-the-uk-test
- **Ecctis QLS:** qls.ecctis.com
- **SARS eFiling:** sars.gov.za
- **Register to vote:** gov.uk/register-to-vote
- **Find a GP:** nhs.uk/service-search/find-a-gp
- **NHS Talking Therapies:** nhs.uk self-referral search
- **Samaritans:** 116 123 (free, 24/7)
- **Child Benefit:** gov.uk/child-benefit
- **Free childcare hours:** gov.uk/get-childcare
- **TV Licence:** tvlicensing.co.uk
- **Compare energy and broadband:** uswitch.com
- **Property search:** rightmove.co.uk | zoopla.co.uk | spareroom.co.uk
- **Driving licence exchange:** gov.uk/exchange-foreign-driving-licence
- **Domestic cleaning:** wecasa.co.uk | housekeep.com | taskrabbit.co.uk
- **Navigation:** citymapper.com
- **Virgin Active (UK and SA access):** virginactive.co.uk
- **Credit score (free):** experian.co.uk | clearscore.com
- **BYP Network:** byp.network | **BWAM:** bwam.network | **EnCircle:** encircle.community
- **London Lekgotla website:** londonlekgotla.com
- **Feedback and suggestions:** London Lekgotla feedback form

A NOTE FROM THE COMMUNITY

Moving to a new country is one of the most courageous things a person can do. It asks you to rebuild: your social world, your professional network, your sense of home, often from scratch, often alone.

London Lekgotla exists because we believe you do not have to do it alone. Every person in this community has stood where you are standing. We have navigated the same visa paperwork, the same grey skies, the same quiet Sundays, and we have found in each other something that feels a little like home.

Show up. Contribute. Ask for help when you need it. Offer it freely when you can.

Pan-African in spirit. Southern African in strategy. Committed to rising together.

This handbook is updated by community members. If anything has changed or you have useful information to add, please use the feedback form above.